

What to buy: CAMERA or CAMCORDER

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The line between a digital camera and a camcorder is increasingly blurring. Almost all point-and-shoot digital cameras now come with movie recording capability. They are becoming even better with HD video capture and optical zoom (5x to 10x). You may also find on them built-in social networking widgets to upload the captured photos directly on the Web.

That may be the reason why camcorder sales are flat to declining in sharp contrast to digital cameras that are showing 25 per cent growth year-on-year. The market is huge as only 3 per cent of Indian homes own a digital camera.

Given this, you may ask what's the point in buying a camcorder?

Camera and camcorder manufacturers are quick to reply that one can't say that camcorders are superior to digital cameras or vice versa. The two are completely different equipment meant for different purposes. Hence the technologies used in them differ widely. Although most digital still cameras can shoot videos, and most camcorders can shoot stills, they are generally not designed to do both at the same level.

You need to understand the difference between a camera and camcorder before you make up your mind to buy one.

Digital cameras vs camcorders

Still image capture and video recording quality. The sensor and image processor of a digital still camera (digicam) is designed to process still images, so it will always have a better picture quality for still pictures. On the other hand, although any good-quality digicam can shoot videos (even HD video at 720p), the quality will often not match that of a mid-range camcorder. This is due to dedicated design of the camcorder's sensor and image processor that can process at constant frame rate.

Lenses/zoom and other hardware. Although many digicams nowadays have very high optical zooming ratios (up to 24x), most camcorders offer a higher zooming range (30x to 60x). This, again, is due to the difference in technology used, and the format.

Most digicams do not use zoom during video recording, while some offer digital zoom. This is done to avoid the sound of the lens motor disturbing the video clip. However, camcorders do not suffer from this disadvantage.

Digital camcorders have a variable-angle (swinging) LCD monitor, in addition to an electronic viewfinder. These features are not present in most digicams.

Storage media options. Most digicams use flash memory cards to record still and video images. But recording time is often limited to as low as 30 sec-

onds, depending upon the format used and the card capacity. Digital camcorders, on the other hand, use a variety of media (flash drives, DVDs, etc) in addition to large internal memories (for example, 60 GB in some models). This means a dedicated digital camcorder can shoot much longer than digicams.

Audio recording. Since most digicams are designed to be very sleek and compact, the microphones and speakers used often don't match the more sophisticated devices used in camcorders. Stereo, surround sound and multi-channel recording are a few among the various audio recording options offered by dedicated digital camcorders.

Ergonomics. Digicams are much smaller, sleeker and compact than digital camcorders. These are designed for easy household usage and hence the emphasis is on portability, design and ease of use.

Digital camcorders, although much smaller nowadays than their older counterparts, are still much bigger than digicams, and handling is also not as simple, due to many features, buttons, etc. Holding the camera steady, especially during high zoom levels, is quite a problem for most users.

Price. Digital camcorders, with their dedicated, sophisticated video recording abilities, cost much more than most digicams. For instance, Canon digital cameras start from around

